The weighty influence of the Israeli media, as is the case in all developed countries, is pronounced. The media to a large degree shape our national agenda. They are controlled by a small number of stakeholders, who are heavily involved in other sectors in the country as well. The media created a situation in which politicians are greatly dependent on them. They directly and indirectly (through advertising) affect our culture of speech and discussion; what we eat and how we dress; and the level and nature of our cultural taste in literature, cinema, theater, and music. In short, the media affect, at least indirectly, our national strength. Therefore, it is necessary and even vital to discuss the series of connections between the media and national strength.

The classic questions regarding the place and role of the media are:

- Is journalism a profession/occupation that is essentially different from other professions? An uneducated person could never be a surgeon but could certainly become a top journalist. An uneducated person could never be a teacher but could certainly become a successful politician. Therefore, a common denominator between a politician and someone who works in the media is that neither field requires formal education or testing. But this is where the common denominators end. There is no question that to be a politician requires national responsibility. As for the journalist, this issue is controversial.
- Is freedom of expression an absolute value? Thomas Jefferson, one of the founding fathers of the United States and its third president, said: "Were it left to me to decide whether we should have a government without newspapers, or newspapers without a government, I should not hesitate a moment to prefer the latter." The First Amendment to the American Constitution in 1791 (which was accepted in large part because of Jefferson's influence) states, "Congress shall make no law . . . abridging the freedom of speech, or of the press." But in practice, from the days of George Washington and through all of America's wars up to the war in Afghanistan, the opposite has been proven. In all its wars, the US government has employed various ways of keeping information from the media, ways that in most (if not all) cases have won public support.